

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Food when cooking is unavailable

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use safe ready-to-eat food, protect drinking water and keep hands and utensils clean. Do not run a camping stove, grill or charcoal indoors. Check food-storage times and temperatures after power loss; never taste suspect food to decide whether it is safe. Plan around dietary and medical needs.

Do now.

- ☐ **Inventory safe food**
01 Count shelf-stable items that can be eaten without heating and identify a manual opener. Separate suspect refrigerated food from safe supplies.
- ☐ **Plan small portions**
02 Open only what can be eaten safely when refrigeration is unavailable. Read the label for storage after opening.
- ☐ **Protect water and hygiene**
03 Use safe water for food and essential washing. Keep preparation surfaces separate from toilet waste and dirty containers.
- ☐ **Keep combustion outside**
04 Use cooking equipment only in the location and manner its instructions allow. Never burn charcoal or use a camp stove inside a room, garage or enclosed balcony.
- ☐ **Include special needs**
05 Plan for infants, allergies, diabetes, swallowing difficulty and pets. Do not change prescribed diets or infant formula preparation without qualified advice.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use known safe shelf-stable food already present and a written meal inventory. If no safe cooking position exists, choose food that does not need cooking rather than improvising an indoor flame.

Watch for.

Food that looks and smells normal can still be unsafe. Do not salvage leaking, swollen or flood-contaminated packaging.

People & practical needs.

Assign portions around actual dietary needs and available safe drinking water. A manual opener should be usable by the person preparing food

Next decision.

Replenish through a verified reachable source before supplies become critical. Set aside easy-to-carry food for movement and avoid creating a plan that depends entirely on fuel or refrigeration.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

Food safety after power loss · official guidance

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/food-without-cooking/>